

15 James Bryce

James Bryce was the son of James Bryce (L.L.D. of Glasgow) and was born at Belfast on May 10 1838. He was educated under his uncle Reuben John Bryce at the Belfast Academy and then continued his education in the University of Glasgow. He went to Trinity College, Oxford, and in 1862 was elected a fellow of Oriel. He went to the bar and practised in London for a few years, but he was soon called back to Oxford as regions professor of civil law (1870–1893). His reputation as a historian had been made as early as 1864 by his work on the Holy Roman Empire. In 1872 he travelled to Iceland to see the land of the Icelandic sagas as he was a great admirer of the Njals saga.

As an author, Bryce was already well known in America. His work *The American Commonwealth* (1888) was the first in which the institutions of the United States had been thoroughly discussed from the point of view of a historian and a constitutional lawyer, and it at once became a classic. His *Studies in History and Jurisprudence* (1901) and *Studies in Contemporary Biography* (1903) were republications of essays, and in 1897, after a visit to South Africa, he published a volume of *Impressions* of that country, which had considerable weight in Liberal circles when the Second Boer War was being discussed. As member of the Liberal opposition in Parliament, Bryce figured as one of the harshest critics of British repressive policy against Boer civilians in the South African partisan war. Taking the risk of being very unpopular for a certain moment, he condemned the systematic burning of farms and the imprisonment of old people, women and children in British concentration camps.

Some Hints on Public Speaking

Eighty years ago Thomas Carlyle preached in favour of Silence and attacked the growing tendency to talk in public. Since then

the habit has increased, is increasing, and seems most unlikely to decrease. It may be true that everything worth saying has been said. Nevertheless, speeches will go on being made as long as men are willing to listen.

You whom I see here present will join—some of you have already joined—the great army of public speakers, so it is natural that you should desire to have a few hints given you on the subject, even if they claim no other authority than that which fifty years of observation here and in Europe may, seem to give. They will be put in the form of a few short hints of a severely practical character. Most, perhaps all, of these hints will appear obvious, but I give them not because they are new, but because they are so constantly neglected as to be worth repeating.

Always have something to say. The man who has something to say and who is known never to speak unless he has is sure to be listened to, especially in a deliberative assembly or wherever there is business to be done, while no one pays attention to the man of mere words. Try to have an idea, or if you cannot find one—ideas are not by any means common—have two or three relevant facts. You may tell me that sometimes a man is forced to speak when there is nothing to be said. This does not often happen, because if you think a little before you rise, you will almost always find something relevant to the matter in hand, even if the occasion is a purely ornamental one. There is a well-known speech of Cicero's in which he had to present a legal case on behalf of a poet. He evidently knew that the legal case was weak, so he passed quickly and lightly over it, but made a graceful and eloquent speech upon poetry in general. The theme was not very new then, and is still less new now, but the speech was so polished in its language that it can still be read with pleasure. So when you have to propose the health of some one of whose personal merits you know nothing, you may say something about the importance of his office if he is a state governor or a mayor, of the services rendered by his profession if he is a surgeon. If you can find nothing at all to say, don't say it. Your silence will not harm you in the long run.

Always know what you intend to say. If possible, consider, before you begin, what you are going to say, and make your own mind

perfectly clear what is the argument which you want to put, or the facts you want to convey. If your own mind is confused, much more confused will your hearers be. Bring your thoughts to a point, reject whatever is irrelevant, and be content if you have one good point and drive it home. It is sad to see how often a man who really has some knowledge of his subject goes searching or stumbling about, trying to get somewhere, but not getting anywhere, not because he lacks words, but because he cannot put his ideas into the form of definite statements.

Always arrange your remarks in some sort of order. No matter how short they are to be, they will be the better if they have a beginning, a middle, and an end. Nothing pleases an audience more than the sense that they are being led along a path towards a definite goal by a man who knows his way. It gives them confidence that the speaker understands what he is doing and will bring them out all right somewhere. Do not, however, let your arrangement be so elaborate as to alarm them. It used to be the fashion of Scottish preachers to divide their subject into three or four sections' with a 'firstly', a 'secondly', a 'thirdly', and so forth, in each section, so that the listener knew what a long road he had to travel. I remember one sermon in which a venerable minister got as far as nineteenthly under the second head. The process of classifying facts and arguments and placing them in their right order in one's own mind helps to make it clear, while it adds strength to the argument. It might almost be said that a well-arranged speech is seldom a bad speech, because in the process of arrangement a man of any sense is sure to find out the deficiencies in his facts or the weak points in his arguments in time to cure them.

Whatever you do, be clear. Make your meaning, whatever it is, plain to your audience. Though unclear speech is usually due to unclear thought, this is not always so. Some persons who think clearly have not learned to express themselves clearly, because they are nervous in public, or have an insufficient command of words. In such cases it may be better to resort to the device, otherwise to be condemned, of reading a speech rather than confuse the audience.... Let the construction of your sentences be simple enough for the hearers to follow, and the words such as they cannot fail

to understand. To find themselves puzzled over your meaning, and while they are still puzzling over your last sentence, to be unable to attend to the next one, annoys your hearers and lessens the chance of pleasing or persuading them.

Never despise those whom you address, whatever you may think of their intellectual attainments. Give them the best you have to give.... Though noisy and empty speech-making will often draw cheers, still the masses of the common people almost always appreciate solid and relevant facts, reasonable and useful thoughts, stated in language they can understand. And there will probably be among them those who would perceive and resent any indication that you were talking down to their inferior capacity.

Use only few superlatives; reserve them for occasions where they will really be effective. Try hard to choose the strong and simple words, and the words that exactly fit the case. Even an audience that is not itself very cultivated feels the charm of language carefully chosen to suit its purpose, and of words that have some touch of colour in them, such as apt metaphors. A well-chosen metaphor often settles an argument finally, or becomes an illustration of it in miniature.

As for humorous stories, and jokes in general, these are essentially matters of individual taste, in which each man will please himself, and few general counsels can be given. Though we all envy the speaker who has plenty of merry jokes, he needs to beware of making excessive use of his gift. There is a tendency today to make after-dinner speaking a mere string of stories, most of which may have little to do with the subject or with one another. Even the best stories lose their charm when they are dragged in by the head and shoulders, having no connection with the subject the speaker is supposed to be dealing with. Relevance as well as brevity is the soul of wit, for a good speech is a work of art, in which every part should be organically related to every other part.

Never, if you can help it, be dull. It is a fault to have too many flowers or too many fireworks, 'but it is a worse fault to be boring. A distinguished Oxford teacher of my undergraduate days, who is now a learned and important English writer, invented for his

pupils a phrase which became very popular in the university: 'It is better to be flippant than to be dull.' This daring advice, meant for young writers, applies even more to young speakers, because, however bad dullness is in print, it is still worse when you cannot escape from it without quitting the dinner table. Many are the causes of dullness in a speech. One is lack of good material, for it often happens that the less a man has to say, the longer he talks about it. A still commoner one is confused thinking, which makes the speaker lose himself in vague and pointless phrases. Another is lack of variety in language, the frequent repetition of the same words, because the speaker's vocabulary is small.

Remember the importance of how you speak. Demosthenes, greatest of all public speakers, is reported to have said when asked what was the chief quality in public speaking, Delivery; and when asked what was the second and again what was the third, to have made the same reply. We are told that his own way of speaking was at first poor, and was improved by ceaseless study and practice. And though a rich or sweet or strong and ringing voice is a gift of nature, care and training can do much to get good results out of a poor organ. Pronunciation, modulation, and expression may all be cultivated. To listen to words clearly and finely spoken, and to sentences in which the voice adapts itself to the subject, adds greatly to whatever pleasure a speech can give.

Were I addressing an English audience I should add a fifth suggestion. *Speak slowly.* But the fault of going too fast is far less common here than in Britain; indeed, some of your speakers tend to the opposite error of going too slow. Dr Phillips Brooks is the only great American to whom I have ever listened who spoke very rapidly. It may interest you to know that John Bright, who was on the whole the greatest English public speaker of the last half century, told me that when he first began to speak in public he spoke so rapidly that on one occasion a newspaper reported an address he had made at a political meeting in the following words: 'The next speech was made by our young townsman, Mr John Bright, but he spoke so fast that our reporter was quite unable to follow him.' When and after Mr Bright had reached the peak of his powers, the

slow, carefully measured way in which he delivered his sentences made them as effective as the blows of a hammer.

Never read your speech if you can avoid it, unless when the occasion is one of such exceptional solemnity or dignity that a long and very polished piece of composition is expected. As for notes, the fewer the better, but if you find that you cannot trust your memory to supply the order of the topics and the particular points you wish to make, or illustrations you wish to include at given places, it is better to refer to your notes for these than to miss the points altogether. There are speakers whose habit it is to carry notes in their pocket even when they hope not to use them. It gives confidence, and saves them from such a disaster as I have seen happen even to practised debaters in the House of Commons, when, having suddenly lost, the thread of what they were saying, they were obliged to sink sadly to their seats, amid the crushing sympathy of the opposing party.

Whether you use notes or not, *always have ready two or three sentences with which to sit down*. You need not be either elaborate or sublime in your final words, but some sort of a summing up you ought to have ready, so as not to get confused and hesitate when the time for ending comes.

Lastly—and this is a hint which is of universal *application never weary your audience*. If they are tired before you rise to speak, cut your speech short, unless you feel able to freshen them up and drive away their weariness. Just as physicians say that a man ought to stop eating while he is still hungry enough to go on eating, so let your hearers wish for more food from you, rather than feel they have had too much already.

You will sometimes make failures, for nobody is always at his best. Do not be discouraged. The fault may not be your own, for much depends on renditions you cannot command. But when you feel you have fallen below the best that you can do, ask yourself why, and if the fault is in your self, try to correct it next time.

About the Essay

James Bryce gives his readers some hints on public speaking. Here are some of his instructions:

Always have something to say, Always know what you intend to say. Always arrange your remarks in some sort of order. What ever you do, be clear. Never despise those whom you address. Use only few superlatives. Relevance as well as brevity is the soul of wit. Never, if you can help it, be dull. Remember the importance of how you speak. Speak slowly. Never read your speech if you can avoid it. Always have two or three sentences ready with which to end your speech. And never weary your audience. These tips will add life to public speaking.

Glossary

Thomas Carlyle: British essayist and historian

deliberative: which discusses things

Cicero: Roman statesman, orator and writer

drive it home: convince people

venerable: someone who deserves respect

talking down to: speaking in a simpler way than usual

in miniature: on a small scale

flippant: without the respect which something deserves

Demosthenes: Greek statesman and orator

delivery: here, the way in which you make a speech, as against what you say in it

modulation: the ways in which you change the tone of your voice when you speak

Phillips Brooks: American Protestant bishop and orator

John Bright: British orator and statesman

The house of commons: the lower house in the British houses of Parliament

lost the thread of: forgotten the sequence of